SPRING SURVEY 2026

Birds of the river valley

Over eight Saturday mornings this spring, a group of six volunteers counted every bird seen or heard along four kilometres of the river, from the mill weir down to the old footbridge.

We logged 585 sightings of 23 species. Mallards were the most common, as every year, but the real news is further down the list: kingfishers are up by more than a third on last spring, and two pairs of dippers are nesting under the footbridge for the first time since the survey began.

This report sets out how we counted, what we found, and what we'd change next year.

METHOD

How we counted

We picked six fixed points along the river, roughly 700 metres apart, chosen for a clear view of the water and both banks. Each point was visited every Saturday from the first weekend of April to the last weekend of May.



At each point one volunteer spent exactly ten minutes recording every bird seen or heard, with the time and species. Birds flying over without landing were noted separately and are left out of the totals here.

Counts started at 6 am. In the first two weeks we also tried starting at 7, which turned out to miss about a third of the birds.

RESULTS

What we saw

SPECIES	SIGHTINGS	VS 2025
Mallard	212	+4%
Grey heron	151	–2%
Kingfisher	109	+38%
Sand martin	81	+11%
Dipper	32	new

Most of the kingfisher sightings came from the two points either side of the weir, where the bank was cut back last autumn and the water runs slower.

NEXT YEAR

What we'd change

Keep the 6 am start. The later counts were consistently lower, and the difference was biggest for the shy species we most want to track.

Add a seventh point below the footbridge, so the dipper nests are covered by a fixed point rather than by whoever happens to walk past.

Record weather and water level at each visit. Two of the lowest mornings followed heavy rain, and without the river level we can't say whether that's the birds or the counting.